

Buertey meeting — Tue 23 Jun 2026, 1:00–4:00 pm

Project on the table: DR200 — *Investor Sentiment, Earnings Surprises & Market Anomalies Leveraging Generative AI* (PEAD). **In the room:** Samuel Buertey (PEAD lead — accounting/ESG) · Anh Tuan Nguyen (Finance, UTA PhD — your method ally on EITHER path) · Hà Xuân Sơn (AI/blockchain — **also team leader of the LLM project #192**).

Goal of the meeting: decide the right *home* for one coherent research interest across the team's two adjacent projects. Target = **LLM project (#192) under DR203 (Finance) + a finance co-sup**. Fallback = **PEAD**, if its framing can be made predictive.

Why this configuration: Applying a two-prong test (predictive verbs AND finance code/discipline/supervisor) across all 250 RMIT VN projects, *neither* project passes both prongs: - **LLM #192** — description is alpha-native (“predict asset prices” ×5, benchmarks vs ARIMA/factor models, LLM-based trading systems) ☐ ... but FoR = 40% Organisational Behaviour / 35% Data Mining / 0% finance, no named finance supervisor ×. - **PEAD #247** — has a finance co-sup (Anh Nguyen) + a 30% finance FoR ☐ ... but framing is accounting-EXPLANATORY (“explain over/under-reaction”), not predictive ×.

Starting from the alpha-native brief and *adding* a supervisor beats starting from an explanatory brief and *fighting* the framing past an accounting lead.

1. Open on shared substance (say it early — non-threatening, true)

“Both your DR200 sentiment project and Son's LLM project sit on the same ground I care about — sentiment, LLMs, earnings reactions, market anomalies. I wanted to use this to figure out which is the right home for the question I'd actually want to answer.”

Puts both projects on the table from sentence one, legitimises Ha Son's project as in-scope, slights no one.

2. Run the predict-vs-explain probe on PEAD

Open with: “*My background's a quant trading desk, so I instinctively frame a sentiment question as 'does this predict returns out-of-sample, after costs.' I want to check that framing fits how you'd want the thesis built.*”

The decisive question — ask it early, neutral either/or (NOT “is this just explanatory accounting?”): > “Would the thesis be judged on whether the sentiment signal **predicts returns out-of-sample, after costs**, or on **explaining** investors' over/under-reaction to earnings? I want to make sure I build toward the right one.”

Offers two legitimate options instead of asking him to admit a flaw → candid answer, and “predicts returns OOS after costs” is specific enough that a hollow “sure, it can be predictive” can't satisfy it. A clean “predictive” answer is ~80% of the decision; still chase Q4 (method ownership) to make it binding.

#	Ask	☑ alive	✗ explanatory/accounting
Q1	Judged on OOS return predictability , or on explaining a relationship?	“predict / survive costs / tradable”	“establish / explain the channel”
Q2	Predictive backtest w/ train-test split, or panel/ event-study?	“walk-forward / hold-out”	“panel / fixed effects” — qual = hard red flag
Q4	[diagnostic — do NOT ask this verbatim] Does Anh Nguyen own the empirical-finance method?	“you’d work with Anh on the empirical side”	“I’d guide all the empirical framing myself”

(Q3 — sentiment source — is already answered GREEN by the brief: broad social media + news, NOT ESG disclosure.)

Q4 — ask as division of EXPERTISE, never as transfer of CONTROL. “Will Anh own the method rather than you?” insults the lead in his own meeting (esp. in an academic/VN hierarchy). Instead: > “Since the project spans accounting, finance, and AI across the three of you — how would you see the supervision dividing up? Who would I mainly work with on the empirical / asset-pricing side, versus the sentiment-extraction and earnings-surprise pieces?”

Standard question, flatters all three (each gets a domain), and the answer reveals method ownership without demanding it. **Let Buerthey describe the split first.** If he hands the empirical lead to Anh on his own → confirmed, cost nothing. If he claims all empirical framing himself → note it silently, don’t push back in the room. Principle (same as Q1): ask the neutral question whose ANSWER is the diagnostic; never ask the diagnostic.

3. Branch on Buerthey’s answer

- **PEAD goes GREEN (predictive + Anh owns method):** PEAD works as primary. Proceed; build an explicitly OOS-return-prediction research statement with Anh Nguyen as method lead.
- **PEAD stays EXPLANATORY/accounting:** pivot to Ha Son, in the room — > “Son — your LLM project’s brief frames the question I’m after directly: predicting asset prices, benchmarking against factor models, capturing signals traditional quant misses. Given my quant-desk back-

ground and QR goal, would that project be the better fit — and could it run under **DR203** so it's examined as finance, with **Anh on board** for the asset-pricing method?"

4. Two structural asks for the LLM path (the prong it's missing)

1. **DR203 enrolment** — confirm the LLM project can be taken under its Finance code (DR201/DR205/DR203), not Business/management.
 2. **A finance supervisor** — float **Anh Nguyen** joining; the LLM team (Ha Son CS + Binh Nguyen econ/crypto) has no named asset-pricing finance lead.
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Diplomacy guardrails (the delicate part)

- **Do NOT** volunteer the FoR-code critique (“your project is 40% organisational behaviour”) — that's your private diagnostic, not something to say to the team that wrote it.
- **Do NOT** frame it as “PEAD is flawed.” Frame as *fit between a coherent interest and the team's two projects*.
- **Anh Nguyen is your ally on either path** — address asset-pricing method questions to him; signals you know who the finance brain is.
- **Leave with PEAD intact**. Don't burn the fallback even if you're aiming for LLM/DR203.

On-the-spot decision rule

- **PEAD green** → take PEAD; LLM is backup.
- **PEAD explanatory AND Ha Son open to LLM-under-DR203 + Anh as co-sup** → that's your primary; only configuration that passes all four prongs.
- **Neither lands** → no RMIT VN project passes the test → seriously weigh other venues for a QR-track PhD.

The model to cite

The team's own “*Decoding market sentiment: ChatGPT explaining Bitcoin returns*” (China Finance Review Int'l, 2025) — proof the predictive/OOS evaluation discipline and the Buertey/Anh/Son division of labour already work in practice.